# The Body Politic

by CJ Harvey



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***Authors Note: The goal of this performance is to explore issues of gender identity and public identity. Therefore, while this script is written from a female perspective, the performer may be of any gender. To that effect, if the performer wishes, the pronouns in the performance (male, female, he, she, wife, husband, etc.) may be altered in order to reflect the performers' preference.***

**GOVERNOR**. (*Enters limping slightly, sore and exhausted. Speaks on the phone.)* No, I have no comment for them. Well, you can tell them that I am looking forward to getting back to work for my constituents.

Yes, you can tell them the president called.

No, you don't tell them I didn't accept the call. Talk about adding insult to injury.

Did the ACLU call back yet?

Dammit. Okay. Well, let me know. Thank you. (*hangs up the phone*)

You know, they never tell you how much it hurts. I mean, obviously, when you get shot it hurts. But the thing is, when it happened, I didn't really feel it.

There was so much screaming, and I was knocked about every which way. I mean, I heard the shot, but I didn't feel anything. When my assistant, Daniel, tackled me to the ground—that hurt. So much so that when he asked me, "Governor Jones, are you okay?" I told him off. I said, "I was fine until you crushed me to death."

And then we saw the blood. But even then, that wasn't when it hurt. It hurt when I woke up in the hospital after surgery.

It hurt when I tried to laugh at my own terrible joke about my cat-like reflexes failing me. Even now two weeks later, it hurts even though they tell me I'm out of danger.

Obviously…doctor's don't read newspapers.

My danger has just begun.

*In April 2015, 20.7 million viewers tuned in to 20/20 to watch Bruce Jenner publicly confirm that she was transgender. Since then, the visibility for transgender Americans has grown exponentially. In fact, nine transgender individuals were elected to public office in 2017.*

*However, such progress was not an overnight phenomenon. In fact, for the better part of the 20th century, transgender individuals have been cast aside as anomalies, mental cases, and even perverts. And unfortunately, the media still treats such stories of personal reclamation and liberation as a sideshow. In her drama, CJ Harvey explores the difference between public approval and personal acceptance, recognizing that the road to progress is often paved with the tears of pioneers.*

**GOVERNOR**. I really don't pretend to know what comes next.

I gave you this interview, because yours in the only newspaper that seems to think that I am still a victim in this.

You're going to have to listen to me on this because I don't have the energy to tell you this multiple times. This whole thing has become such a twisted mess. I don't necessarily feel the need to defend myself but some have insinuated that all of this started because somewhere along the line I decided I didn't need to be truthful.

So let me be clear: I didn't decide anything. Some man decided to shoot me for reasons unknown. Some nurse or an intern decided that the world had a right to know my personal medical history. And the press decided that I… look, I am fine with being labeled a freak…an…an abomination, or whatever language you'd like to use. But I was *never* a liar.

But, just to…confirm…what every newspaper in the country is obsessed with reporting: yes, I was born a male, biologically.

And I say biologically, because to me, that's an important distinction. I mean, people change their biological form all the time. You might have been born a blonde or a redhead and desired to change that. You might have been born with genes that lent themselves to be overweight, but you worked hard to claim the life—the identity—that you wanted for yourself. And no one is standing outside your house with hateful signs that say you "defied God."

I was born a male, but I have always been a woman. And my husband and I have had many, many conversations about the differences between male and female, man and woman. We say a woman is someone who owns her femininity, someone who identifies psychologically, culturally, and spiritually as part of a sisterhood of women. Someone who sees other women and thinks "That's what I am."

It was around four years old that I started noticing that I didn't quite…fit…in my own skin. My parents were always correcting me. "No, sweetie. Y=You're a boy," or "Say he."

The only day I truly felt comfortable was Halloween. And no, I didn't dress up as a girl.

I was Superman.

Every year.

Because I understood what it was like to walk through the world like an alien, you know? And all I wanted was to disappear into a phone booth and emerge a completely different person. My true self.

I wasn't Sam. I was Samantha, and I was lucky to figure it out very early in my life. And when I told my parents, they were incredibly kind. They were proud to have a child who knew her own mind.

It doesn't matter when I physically transitioned. Do you hear me? It doesn't. What matters is when I embraced who I was. It was the same year I decided I wanted to go into public service, to be a different kind of Superman—you know, truth, justice and The American Way.

It was the same year I met the love of my life. And when I told him my story, do you know what he said to me? "Samantha, you are the most courageous person I know. Not for what you've been through. That's only part of the story."

In the hospital, the look on my husband's face when I woke up… He was so relieved and so, so sad—like he knew it was going to be far worse for me to wake up than to just slip away.

Maybe I should have.

But that's not who I am. Yes, to call me transgender is accurate, but that's only part of the story.

The rest of the story could have been that I got married in a church, I ran for city council, I worked my way up to chairman. I instituted changes that helped students from all over my city get a better education, I helped public transportation improve so seniors could access health care. I ran for Governor on a positive, issue-based platform, and I won. I work tirelessly to make the world better, and maybe that sounds cheesy, but what the hell? It's what I believe in and *that's* what people should care about.

What I value.

What I fight for.

But no.

The only story people care about is the front of these damned newspapers!

"The Scandal in the Governor's Mansion"

"How Far Did the Cover-Up Go?"

"Is the Governor's Husband Gay?"

Now I am finished. I won't resign, but I'll never be re-elected. The world we live in remembers headlines not articles of the Constitution. And I could sue. I would absolutely have grounds for slander and libel and all of it—but, on some level, wouldn't it be worse for them to be able to paint me as some self-loathing transphobic nobody, instead of the governor? The governor who almost dodged one bullet, but couldn't escape another. Truth, justice, and The American Way, right?

I want to tell people that I think it's sick. I think it's sick that the focus here is not on gun violence, it's not on mental health issues, it's not even on the fact that public debate has devolved so far in this country that a citizen whom I would have gladly listened to, felt the need to…to…

For God's sake, I almost died!

And the only thing people care about is what is between my legs!

I am so, so tired of apologizing for making myself into the person I already was.

You wonder why I never felt the need to tell people?

I gave you this interview because you're the only one who wants to talk about the shooting. Ironic that it's the only thing I haven't talked about. But that's the thing about truth: it comes out whether you want it to or not.

I just wanted someone to know me. Not for myself but for all of us. For the men and women I am so proud to serve.